Babur's throne, it seems. Sometime in the summer of 1529, eighteen-odd months before Babur died, Humayun left Badakhshan – his fief for almost a decade – and hurried down to his father's court in Agra. He went uninvited but, as he told his brother Kamran – surprised to see Humayun riding south through Kabul – 'he was always seeing [Babur] with his mind's eye, yet this was not equal to a personal interview'.[25]

Annette Beveridge, translator of both the *Humayun-nama* and Babur's memoirs, suggests that Babur wasn't flattered by such filial devotion. Badakhshan was not just a distant outpost of the newly formed empire; it was central to Babur's dreams for his dynasty. Though it appears historically inevitable, today, that the Mughals would rule Hindustan, Babur's great ambition had been to conquer the magnificent capital of his ancestor Timur – Samarqand; and even now, settled uncomfortably in the north Indian plains, Babur kept his two eldest sons north of the Indus – Humayun in Badakhshan, Kamran in Kabul – possibly to push conquests in that direction.

Humayun's unexpected arrival, however, was compounded by a stubborn refusal to leave. Soon after the prince appeared in Agra, there followed news that Badakhshan was besieged, but when Babur suggested that Humayun might like to go and defend his fief, the prince declared that having so long 'suffered' the lack of his father's presence, he had 'vowed . . . [to] never again . . . exile himself' from it. Thus it was that Babur's nephew, young Sulaiman, went to rescue Badakhshan – and went on to take it for his own – while Humayun settled in Sambhal, where he 'remained happily' for six months until he fell ill, thus setting the course for Babur's demise.[26]

Is it possible that if Humayun had followed his father's instructions, or Mahdi Khwaja had been less treacherous, the Mughal empire would have grown towards Bukhara, not Bengal? 'There is mist over the scene,' writes Beveridge, 'from which only the accomplished facts emerge.'[27] Humayun, that is, was neither too unworldly nor too abstracted to nurse ambition. He wanted Babur's throne in Hindustan and he got it.

And now, in 1540, he had lost it. All of it, even Badakhshan – now held by Sulaiman. At some point during those unhappy months in Lahore, discussing possibilities threadbare, Humayun had declared, rather